

Miracle at Philadelphia: Forging a More Perfect Union



From the brink of collapse to the signing of the United States Constitution.

MAY – SEPTEMBER 1787

A hot, sealed room and a vow of silence.

On May 25, 1787, delegates gathered in Philadelphia. While the stated goal was to revise the Articles of Confederation, the sessions were shrouded in secrecy to allow delegates to speak their minds without outside pressure.

To maintain this privacy, the windows were kept tightly closed despite the summer heat.

New England delegates suffered in their heavy woolen suits, while Southerners accustomed to the warmth fared better. The "hot room" became the crucible for the nation's future.

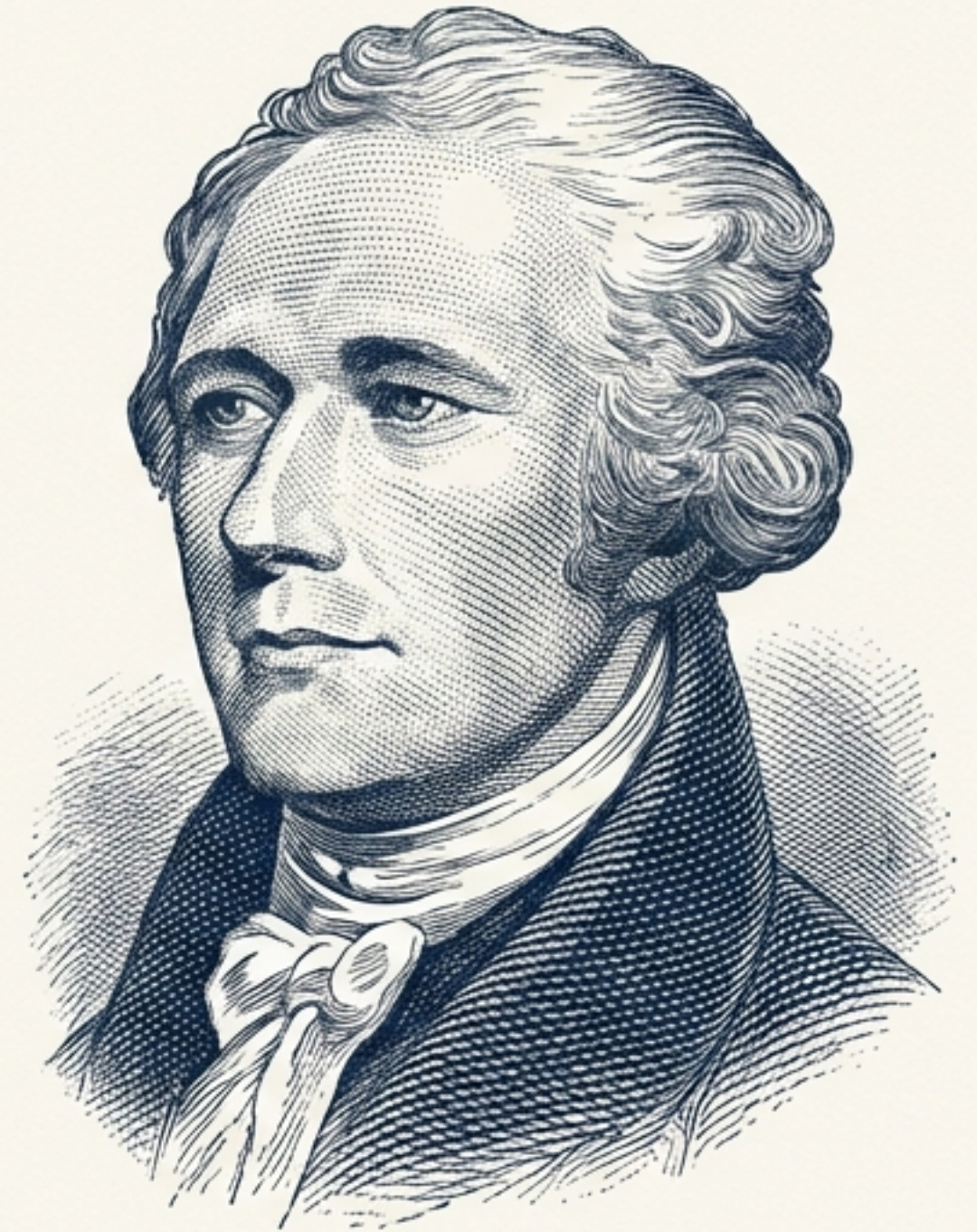


The nation was sick and required a powerful remedy.

“The nation is sick and wants powerful remedies.”

— Alexander Hamilton

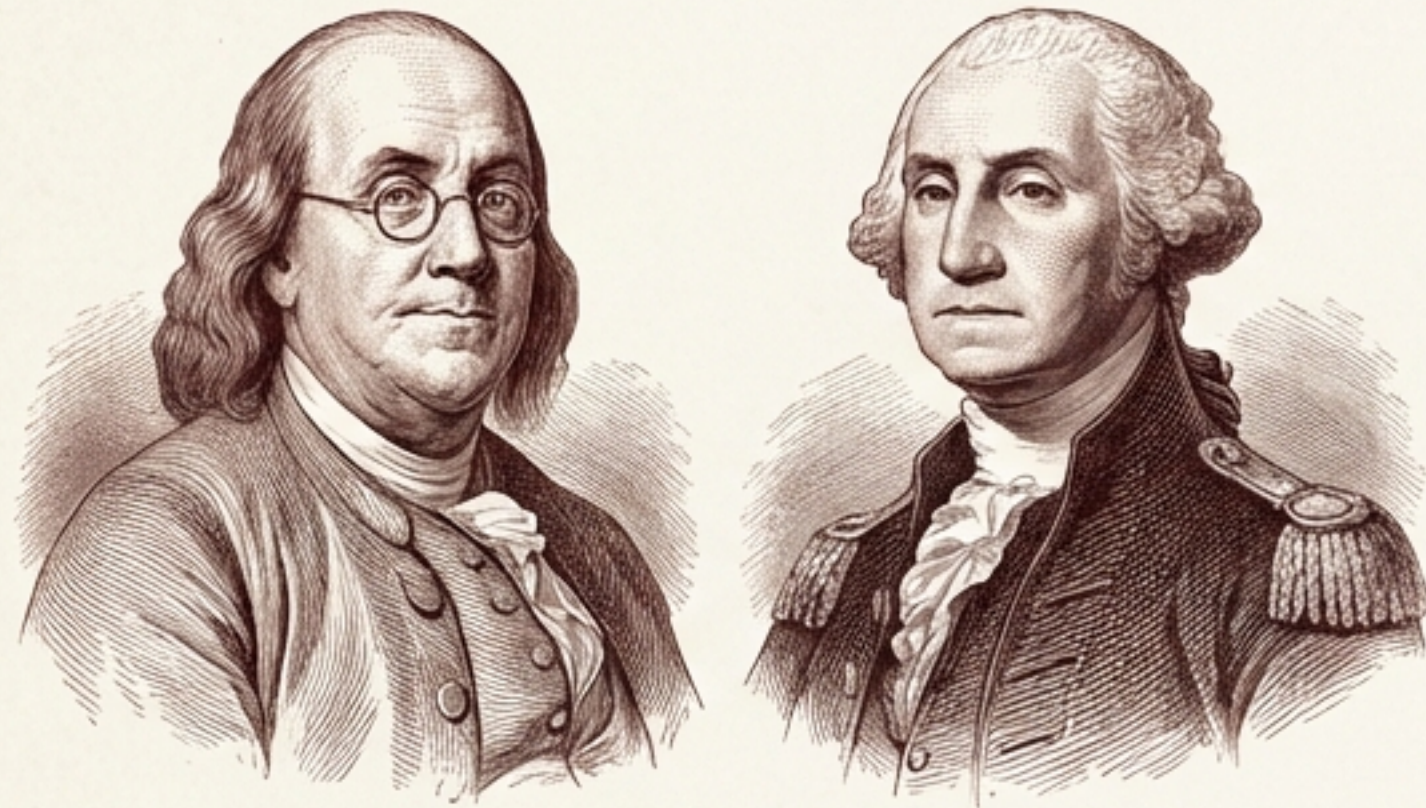
Most delegates represented a new generation of leaders who despised the weakness of the current government. Hamilton, a delegate from New York and former private secretary to Washington, argued for a strong central government.



Quickly, the realization set in: simply revising the Articles of Confederation was insufficient. They needed to write an entirely new constitution.

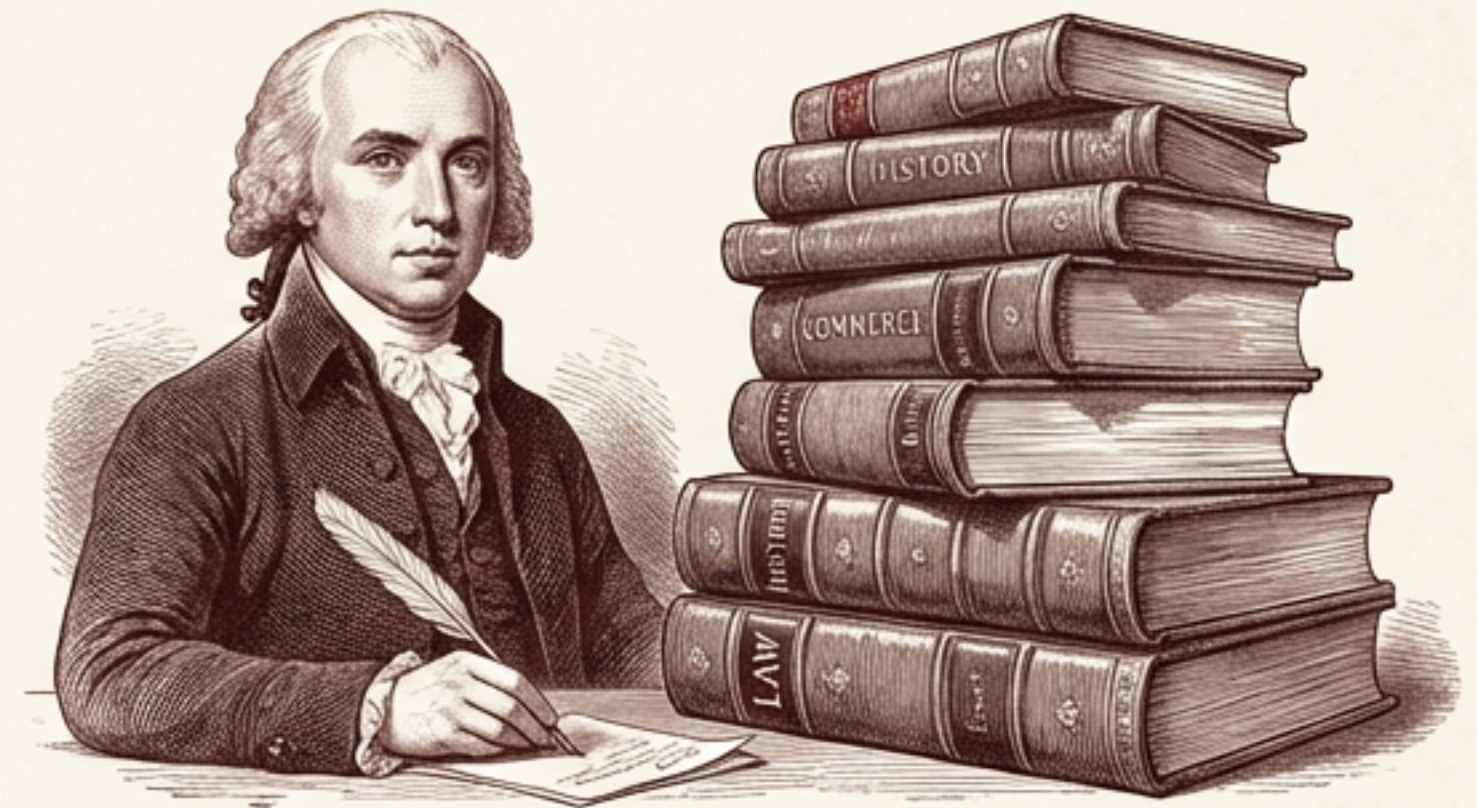
A convergence of civic virtue and intellect.

The Authority



81-year-old Benjamin Franklin brought wisdom on human nature, while George Washington, respected enough to be elected president of the Convention immediately, provided steady leadership.

The Architect



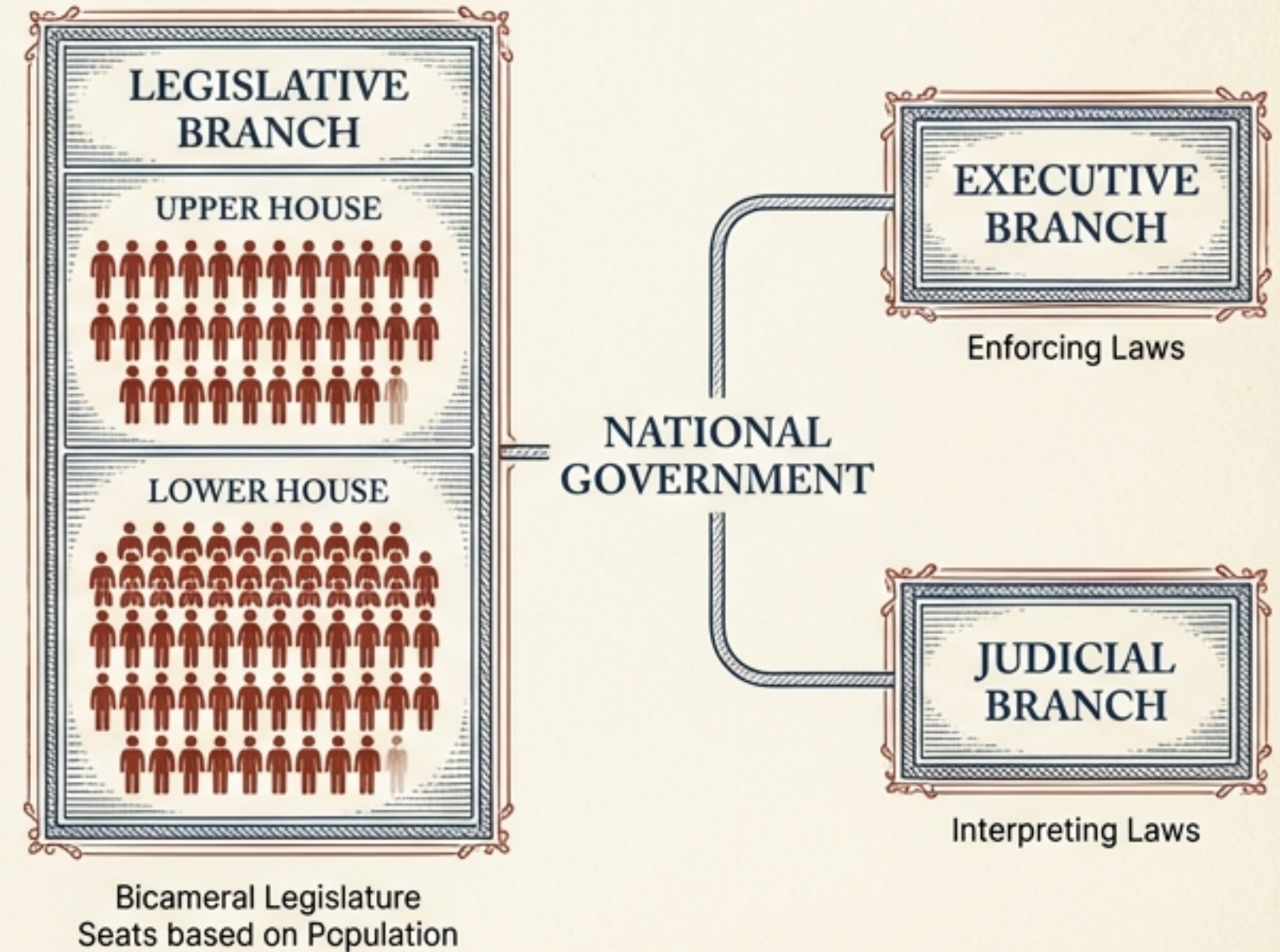
James Madison, 36, arrived with a “case bulging with volumes of research.” Quiet and shy, he had spent months studying history and commerce. His preparedness would earn him the title “Father of the Constitution.”

The Virginia Plan proposed a government based on population.

Proposed by Edmund Randolph and James Madison, this plan called for a strong national government with three branches: Legislative (passing laws), Executive (enforcing laws), and Judicial (interpreting laws).

The legislature would be bicameral (two houses). Crucially, seats would be awarded based on population.

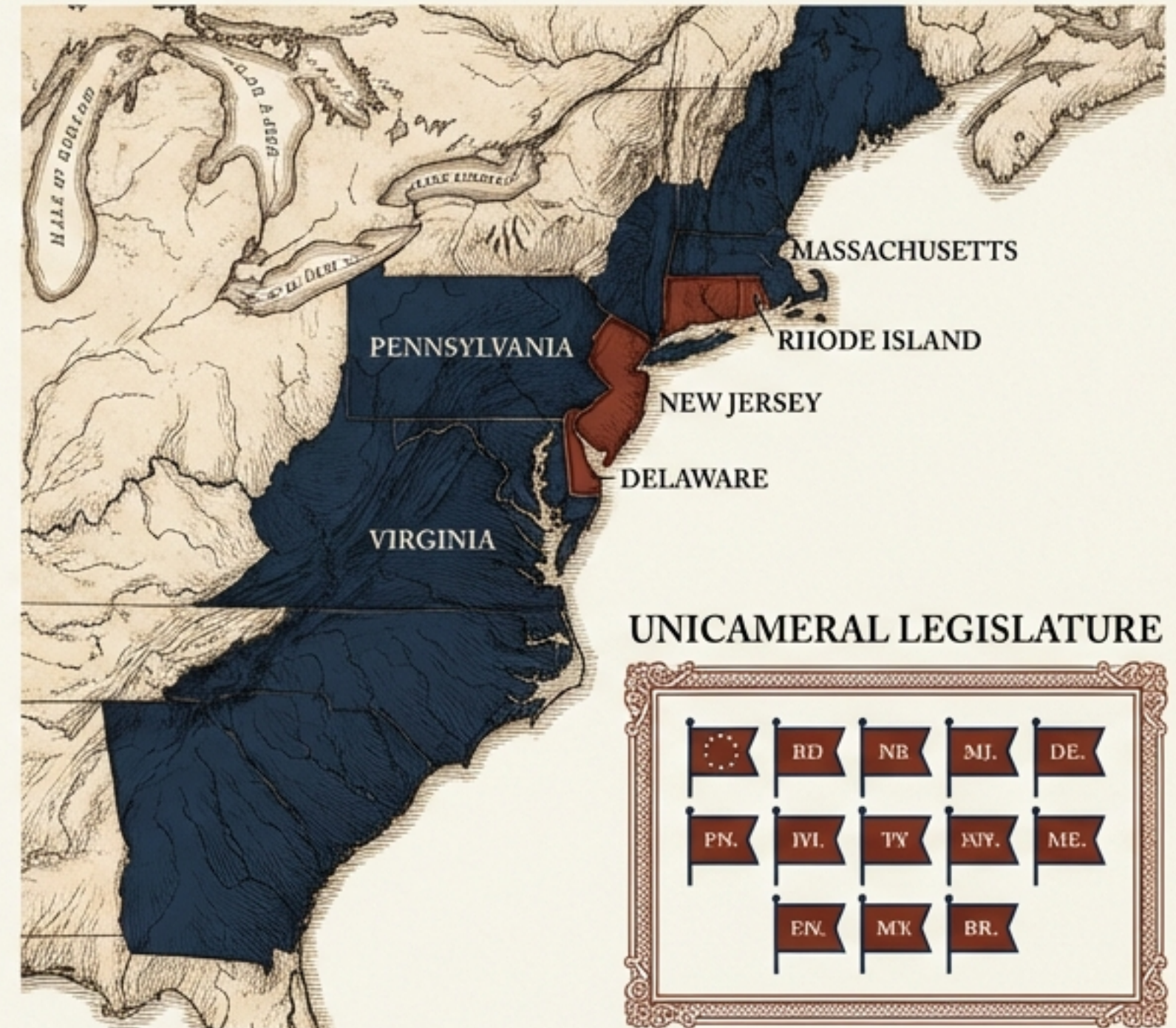
Implication: Larger states would hold significantly more power than smaller ones, a radical shift from the "one state, one vote" system of the Articles.



Small states feared being swallowed by their larger neighbors.

After two weeks of debate, William Paterson of New Jersey countered the Virginia Plan. The small states refused to hand over dominance to Virginia, Pennsylvania, and Massachusetts.

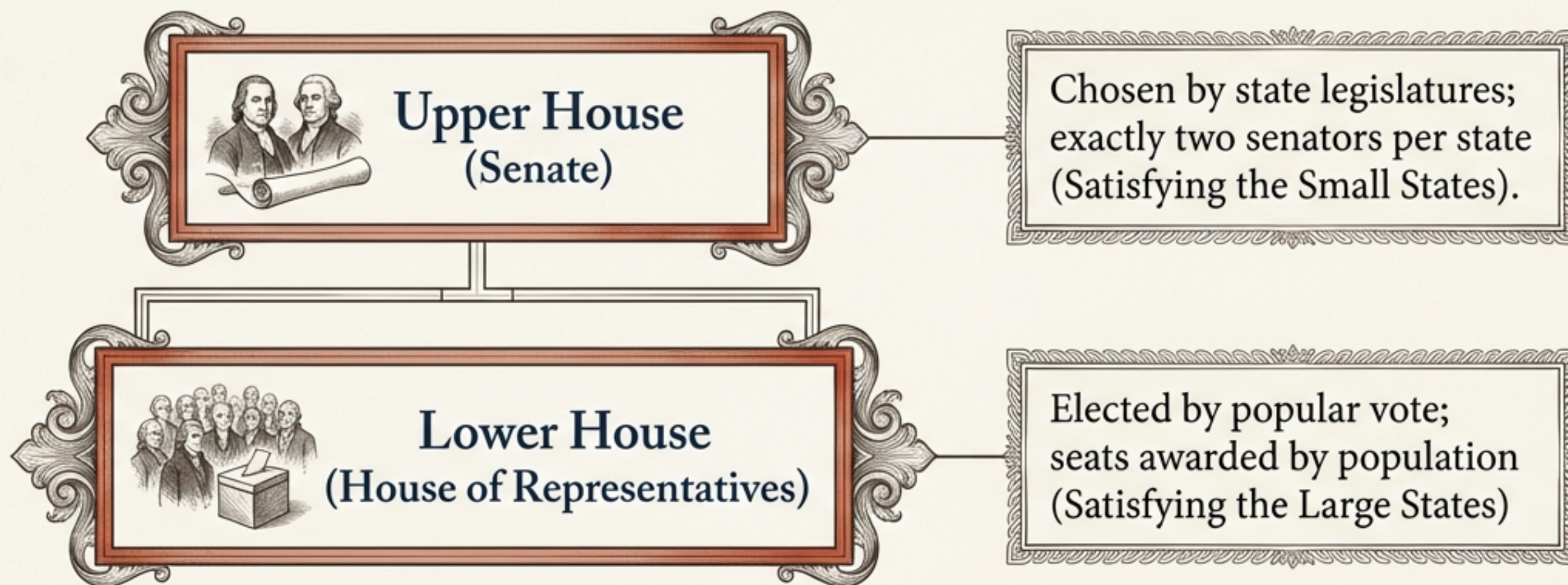
The New Jersey Plan also called for three branches, but it insisted on a unicameral (one house) legislature where each state had one vote, regardless of population.



Tension: The Convention deadlocked. Tempers flared, and the entire endeavor threatened to collapse.

A Great Compromise saved the convention from failure.

Roger Sherman of Connecticut proposed a solution to satisfy both sides.



Outcome: On July 16, the plan passed by a margin of just one vote. This “admirable show of civic virtue” allowed the work to continue.

A deep divide formed over how to count the enslaved.

Would enslaved people be counted as part of a state's population for representation?

Southerners wanted enslaved African Americans included in the population count to gain more seats in the House of Representatives, despite not allowing them to vote.



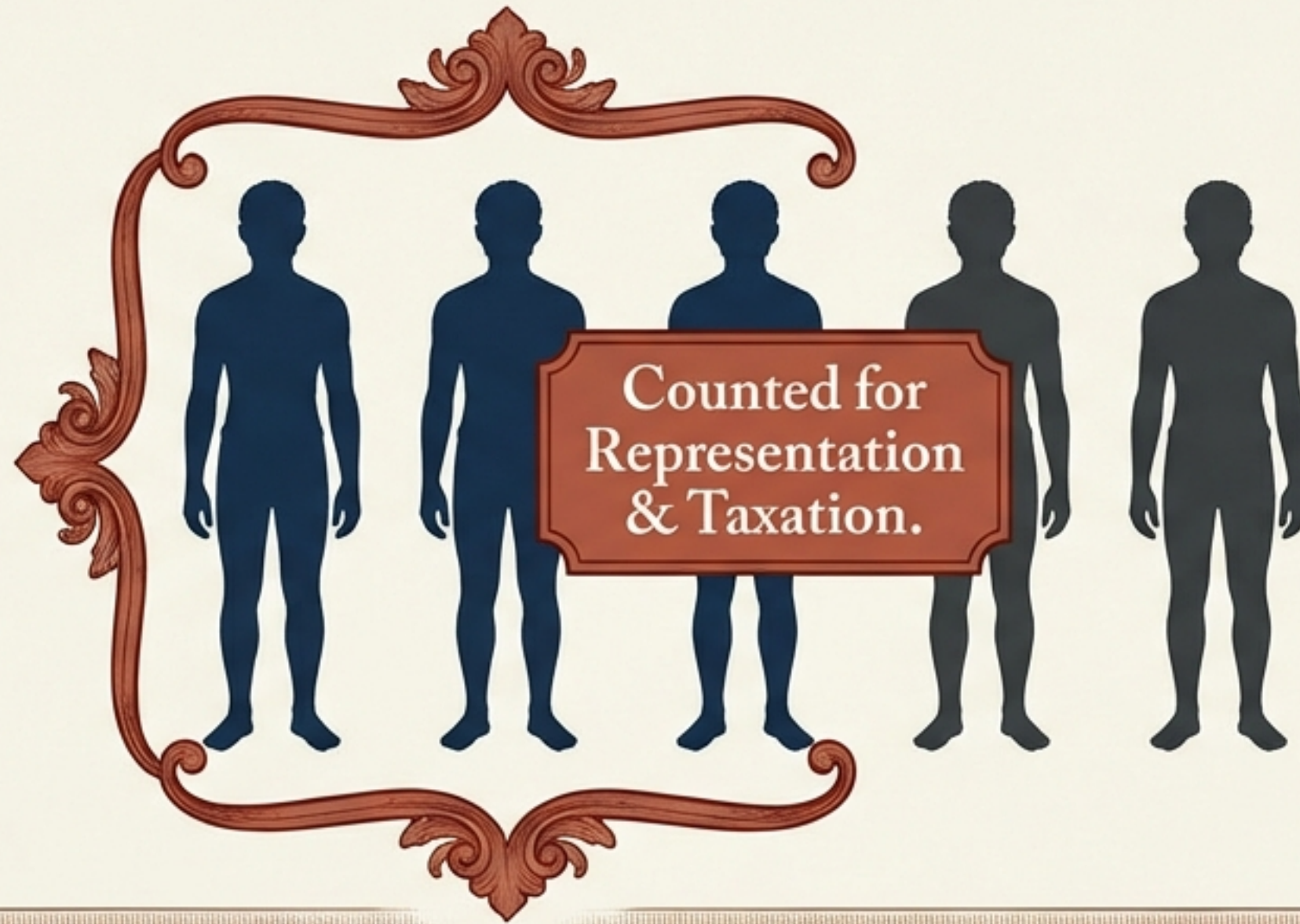
Northerners objected, arguing that since enslaved people were denied the vote, they should not be counted for the purpose of assigning political power.



The Three-Fifths Compromise.

The Deal:

Delegates agreed that three-fifths of the enslaved population in any state would be counted. (e.g., 3,000 counted out of 5,000 enslaved residents).



The Origin:

This specific fraction was not invented in 1787; it was borrowed from a tax rule in the Articles of Confederation.

The Trade-off: The compromise used this pre-existing rule to balance Northern and Southern concerns: the count would apply to assigning representatives (helping the South) and assigning taxes (costing the South).

Economic threats led to a moratorium on banning the slave trade.

- **The Disagreement:** Some Northern states had already banned the slave trade and urged a **national ban**. Southern delegates argued such a ban would ruin their economies.
- **The Resolution:**
 1. **20-Year Window:** Congress was forbidden from outlawing the slave trade for at least 20 years.
 2. **Regulation:** After that period, Congress could regulate it if they wished.
 3. **Fugitive Clause:** Northerners agreed that no state could stop a person fleeing slavery from being returned to an owner.



Finishing the framework of a new government

Executive

- Tenure of the President

Judiciary

- Organization of federal courts

Logistics

- Payment for members of Congress



Doubt a lig little of his own infallibility.



I **doubt...** whether any other Convention... **may be able to make a better Constitution...** I cannot help expressing a wish, that every member of the Convention who may still have objections to it, would with me, on this occasion, **doubt a little of his own infallibility,** and... put his name to this instrument.

Gathering for the last time, Franklin acknowledged the imperfections but pleaded for unanimity.

September 17, 1787: The Signing.



The Event:

One by one, the delegates came forward. All but three of those remaining in Philadelphia signed the Constitution.

The Dissenters:

Edmund Randolph (VA), George Mason (VA), and Elbridge Gerry (MA) refused.

The Reason:

They feared the new Constitution granted too much power to the national government, lacking sufficient protection for individual rights.

The challenge shifted from Philadelphia to the States.



The Process:

The creation of the Constitution was only the first step. It set in motion a process requiring each state to hold its own convention to approve or reject the plan.

The Threshold:

The Constitution would not become the law of the land until **nine states endorsed it.**

The delegates had done their part; now the decision rested with the people.